

Dounreay Nuclear

PMO Service Review & Portfolio Management

Strengthening governance, portfolio control, and
delivery confidence in a complex multi-vendor
environment

Dounreay Nuclear – PMO Service Review & Portfolio Management

Executive summary

As PMO Manager at Dounreay Nuclear, I was engaged to assess, stabilise and enhance the organisation's project management service capability.

Working within a multi-vendor environment and a service integrator model, I combined rigorous governance, commercial awareness and strategic leadership to improve control across a complex portfolio landscape.

The engagement established a mature, commercially aware PMO service, strengthened governance, improved delivery confidence and enhanced collaboration across internal teams and external partners.

Project snapshot

At a glance

A PMO service review and portfolio management engagement focused on improving governance, delivery assurance, vendor coordination and organisational alignment.

Area	Summary
Organisation	Dounreay Nuclear
Role	PMO Manager
Operating context	Multi-vendor environment and service integrator model
Portfolio scope	Concurrent projects across engineering, IT and infrastructure
Headline outcome	A mature PMO service with stronger governance and improved delivery confidence

The challenge

The starting point was a project management service that required assessment, stabilisation and enhancement. Its structure, processes and alignment with organisational objectives needed to be understood before a practical improvement plan could be established.

The operating environment added further complexity. Delivery took place across multiple vendors within a service integrator model, while the portfolio spanned engineering, IT and infrastructure. This required a consistent approach to governance, delivery assurance, commercial management and coordination across organisational boundaries.

The role therefore called for more than portfolio oversight. It required strategic leadership, clearer control and stronger connections between operational execution, vendor performance and organisational priorities.

Initial service review and assessment

My first priority was to conduct a comprehensive review of the existing PMO service. I evaluated its structure, processes and alignment with organisational objectives, identifying improvement areas across governance, delivery assurance and vendor coordination.

The review combined assessment with practical recommendations for service improvement and optimisation. Key activities included:

- **Service assessment** — Conducted a full PMO service assessment and maturity review.
- **Improvement planning** — Documented recommendations for service improvement and optimisation.

- **Governance design** — Defined governance enhancements and delivery frameworks.
- **Leadership engagement** — Presented the findings and improvement roadmap to senior leadership.

The outcome was a clear, actionable plan to elevate PMO performance and strengthen delivery predictability.

Portfolio management and delivery

I led the portfolio management and delivery function, ensuring that strategic objectives remained aligned with operational execution. This included oversight of multiple concurrent projects across engineering, IT and infrastructure domains.

My responsibilities covered:

- **Portfolio planning** — Prioritisation and resource allocation across the portfolio.
- **Delivery oversight** — Tracking delivery and producing performance reporting.
- **Risk and issue management** — Managing risks and issues across workstreams.
- **Vendor coordination** — Coordinating with the service integrator and third-party vendors.

Through disciplined governance and transparent reporting, the PMO became a trusted source of delivery insight and control.

Financial and commercial management

Operating within a multi-vendor environment, I managed the P&L for the PMO service, with a focus on cost efficiency and contractual compliance. This connected financial obligations with delivery milestones and strengthened accountability across the delivery ecosystem.

Key areas of focus included:

- **Cost control** — Established cost-tracking and forecasting mechanisms.
- **Contract management** — Managed vendor contracts and performance metrics.
- **Delivery alignment** — Ensured financial obligations remained aligned with delivery milestones.
- **Commercial support** — Supported commercial negotiations and service-level adherence.

This financial stewardship reinforced accountability and value realisation across the delivery ecosystem.

Leadership and team management

As line manager for the PMO team, I focused on building capability, clarifying roles and embedding continuous improvement. The objective was to create the conditions for

consistent delivery and stronger alignment with organisational priorities and stakeholder expectations.

My focus areas included:

- **Team leadership** — Providing leadership, mentoring and direction.
- **Capability development** — Supporting skills development and performance management.
- **Resource planning** — Balancing resources and workloads across the team.
- **Team culture** — Embedding collaboration and delivery excellence.

The result was a cohesive, high-performing PMO team aligned to organisational priorities and stakeholder expectations.

Strategic impact

The engagement delivered a mature, commercially aware PMO service capable of managing complex portfolios within a regulated nuclear environment.

By bringing together stronger governance, disciplined portfolio management, transparent reporting, commercial stewardship and focused team leadership, the service improved delivery confidence and control.

It also enhanced collaboration across internal teams and external partners, creating a more connected delivery ecosystem and a clearer basis for managing portfolio activity.

Closing takeaway

The engagement demonstrated the value of treating the PMO as an integrated service rather than an administrative function. Effective governance, portfolio oversight, commercial management and team capability worked together to strengthen delivery predictability and organisational confidence.

Key takeaway

In a complex, multi-vendor environment, a mature PMO can create meaningful value by connecting strategic priorities with operational delivery, financial accountability and collaborative leadership.